



GO-TO-MARKET RESEARCH

Mad Monkey AI **First 1,000** campus users.

What the case studies say, what transfers to us,
and a 16-week roadmap to a repeatable campus playbook.



Compiled from case studies, Substacks and videos | October 2026

Real-Time Action Network for students

01 | THE SHORT VERSION

Our problem isn't reach. It's density.

Spark only works when someone answers within minutes. A few campuses packed with users beat many campuses with a handful each. Every play below is judged on one question: does it get a critical mass of students onto the same campus, fast?

01

Win one campus at a time

Fizz launched at a campus its founders knew and hit ~10% of undergrads in a week. TBH unlocked the app school by school.

SEEN IN: Fizz, TBH

02

Make the product the hero

Tolan's creator videos showed real people using Tolan. Cluely's skits got fans, not downloads.

SEEN IN: Tolan, Cluely

03

Find the connectors

Someone already gathers your users: Runna's coach, Granola's VCs, micro-influencers, meme pages, club heads.

SEEN IN: Runna, Granola, Shezaar

04

Give them a moment worth sharing

Wordle's result grid spread itself. Lapse forced invites, users gamed it, downloads dropped 70%.

SEEN IN: Wordle, Lapse

05

Trust is a growth feature

Verified campuses, local moderators and locked-down data kept Fizz alive where Yik Yak died of toxicity.

SEEN IN: Fizz, Yik Yak

06

Measure from day one

Analytics dashboard is priority one in the notes: live, active, retention, per-campus density.

SEEN IN: Your notes

If we only do three things

- **Instrument everything** before spending a rupee on acquisition.
- **Win one campus** to real density before touching a second.
- **Show the product working** in every piece of content: a Spark posted, answered, filled.

02 | WHAT WORKED FOR OTHERS

Case studies, boiled down

CASE 01

Fizz: win one campus you actually know

700+

users in week one at Stanford

~10%

of undergrads joined in that week

~\$500

per month paid to student moderators (Amherst, Bates)

WHAT THEY DID

- Launched at Stanford on 29 Jul 2021 after testing at Cornell and UChicago. Founders knew the campus.
- Campus-locked feeds via verified college email. Stanford students couldn't see Rice's community.
- Launch-leader ambassadors recruited more ambassadors and handed out donuts and merch. Hundreds of downloads on day one at some campuses, though many went inactive or deleted.
- Used existing meme pages for reach (Seattle University).
- Recruited ~15 moderators at Amherst within weeks, trained via modules, expected to post 30-40 times a day.

WHAT WE TAKE FROM IT

- **Yik Yak** died of toxic content, so downvotes weren't enough. Fizz answered with local human moderation.
- Weak database rules exposed users' phone numbers and emails. The legal threat that followed made it worse. Security is a launch blocker.
- **Timing:** lockdown made friend-making a real need. Our version of a pressing need is worth defining (hackathon and fest seasons?).
- Donuts and merch are the US version of an incentive. Ours is probably chai, snacks, merch and ambassador payouts.

CASE 02

TBH: one school at a time

- Private Instagram account per school. Followed every student, then accepted all follow-backs at once, right as the school day ended.
- Sent an ambiguous DM invite. The app **unlocked per campus** once enough students downloaded.
- Result: ~40% of the school on the app by day two.
- **Takeaway:** a campus-level unlock builds curiosity and fixes the empty-room problem.

CASE 03

Tolan: UGC where the product is the star

- Paid creators, mostly college students, to post ordinary-day videos: studying at 3 AM with Tolan, asking it for advice.
- About 1 in 20 videos popped, bringing 10-15k installs in a day.
- Some apps pay as little as \$5 per 1,000 views.
- **Takeaway:** a viewer must be able to see themselves using it.

MORE PLAYS FROM THE NOTES

CASE 04

Connectors: one yes, many users

- **Runna:** cofounder Ben Parker coached ~40 runners online. They became the first users.
- **Granola:** started with VCs, a small group that takes lots of notes and talks a lot. Their founders followed.
- **Shezaar:** micro-influencers in sustainable fashion.
- **Takeaway:** start with a group small enough to unlock network effects, then let it spread.

CASE 05

Shareable moments

- **Wordle:** the green-and-yellow grid made people share. Went from ~90 players to ~300,000 in two months.
- Find the moment users feel proudest and make it easy to share.
- **Lapse:** forced users to invite five friends. They found loopholes and downloads fell 70% after a strong start.
- **Takeaway:** never force it.

CASE 06

Content that gets fans but not users

- **Cluely** turned engineers into creators posting 3 videos a day. Great awareness, but few people download because of an office skit. The product wasn't the hero.
- **Shezaar** spent two months posting everywhere (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok, Substack, Reddit): thousands of followers, zero leads.
- **The rule:** people care what the product does for them, not the product itself. Sell the reason to care, and let the product be the thing doing it.

PLAYBOOK

Cheap channels from the notes

- **Reddit** post as a quick test, most plausibly for Build Spark audiences (hackathon and dev communities).
- **Trend-riding:** find viral content in our niche and adapt it. Promote events and apps through current social trends.
- **Hire UGC creators** and budget for misses. At a 1-in-20 hit rate, plan 20 videos per breakout.
- **Local student influencers:** every college has reel-makers with a campus following. Local marketing worked for Fizz.

03 | LAUNCH INFRASTRUCTURE

What has to exist before we push users in

ITEM	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN
Analytics dashboard	Live users, active users, retention, Spark metrics, per-campus density. Top priority in the notes.	NOW
Waitlist + landing page	Gauges interest, builds a beta-tester base, collects emails and notifies at launch.	NOW
Store listings	App Store and Play Store. Screenshots are the first thing people judge. Strong title, description and tags.	PRE-LAUNCH
In-app feedback board	Collect feature requests and show them inside the analytics view.	PRE-LAUNCH
Email sequence	Programmatic onboarding and re-engagement. Loops has a free plan.	PRE-LAUNCH
UGC creator program	Paid creators, product-as-hero videos, trend-riding formats.	LAUNCH
Reddit / community posts	Cheap test, especially for Build Spark audiences.	LAUNCH
Case study	Write up what worked on campus #1. This becomes the playbook for campus #2.	AFTER

Events worth tracking from day one (suggested)

Acquisition: signup, verified signup, source (ambassador, creator, referral, store). **Activation:** first Spark posted, first Spark accepted, first chat opened. **Density:** Sparks per campus per day, share of Sparks with a response, median time to first response. **Retention:** D1, D7, D30, weekly active. **Virality:** share-card taps, invites sent and accepted. **Voice:** feedback submissions, tagged by feature.

04 | TRUST, VERIFICATION AND LEGAL

Boring infrastructure that decides if we survive

Anything can happen in a location-aware student app. Fizz's moderation and verification were part of its growth engine, not a cost centre.

VERIFICATION LADDER

Gating signups is friction, but friction can be the filter

STEP 1

College email

Only campus domains allowed (e.g. a student-domain address; Gmail blocked). Cleanest, filters organic real students.

STEP 2

ID or receipt upload

For colleges with no email. Let users in right away, restrict posting or reacting until a moderator verifies.

STEP 3

Automated verification

SheerID-style, as used by Spotify and others. Future scope.

Open question: how many target colleges issue student emails at all? This decides whether step 1 can be the default.

MODERATION

Humans on the ground

- Fizz used a local moderation team from day one and added moderators as it grew.
- Pay ranged from volunteer to ~\$500/month for hitting posting and review targets.
- Training modules came before anyone moderated.
- For us: Sparks bring strangers together in the real world, so add report, block and public-meetup nudges.

LEGAL AND SECURITY

Check before launch

- Lock down database access rules before any public launch. Fizz's early misconfiguration exposed phone numbers and emails.
- Many first-years are 17. Under India's DPDP Act, users under 18 are children with extra consent duties. Verify the specifics with counsel.
- Location data and chat make this a sensitive product. Decide who owns moderation and legal early, possibly a dedicated person.

05 | APPLYING IT TO MAD MONKEY

Six plays that fit Spark and Discover

Mapped from the research. These are proposals to test, not proven tactics for us.

FROM TBH

Campus unlock

- A campus unlocks Sparks once N verified students sign up, with a live counter.
- Builds curiosity and solves the empty-room problem.
- Unlock is campus-wide, not an individual invite gate, so no Lapse-style gaming.

FROM GRANOLA

Start with Build Sparks

- Hackathon crowds, coding clubs, E-cells and robotics teams are small, talkative and need teammates urgently.
- Once they use it, everyone else hears about it.
- Feeds Venture Club later.

FROM RUNNA AND FIZZ

Recruit the connectors

- Club heads, fest organisers, hackathon organisers, meme pages and campus creators.
- One yes brings dozens of users.
- Ambassadors recruit ambassadors, like Fizz's launch leaders.

FROM WORDLE

A shareable proud moment

- A 'team formed' card, or 'Spark filled in 7 minutes' for Stories.
- Opt-in and never gating access.
- Find the moment a user feels proudest and make it a one-tap share.

FROM TOLAN

Product-as-hero content

- Screen-record a real Spark: posted at 6:02, three replies by 6:09.
- Day-in-the-life clips: found a Flutter dev for the hackathon.
- Budget 20 videos per breakout. Floor price ~\$5 per 1,000 views.

FROM FIZZ

Seed the supply

- The team posts Sparks and seeds Discover profiles so a new user's first open is never empty.
- Moderators double as seeders, like Fizz's 30-40 posts a day.
- Remove seeding as organic volume takes over.

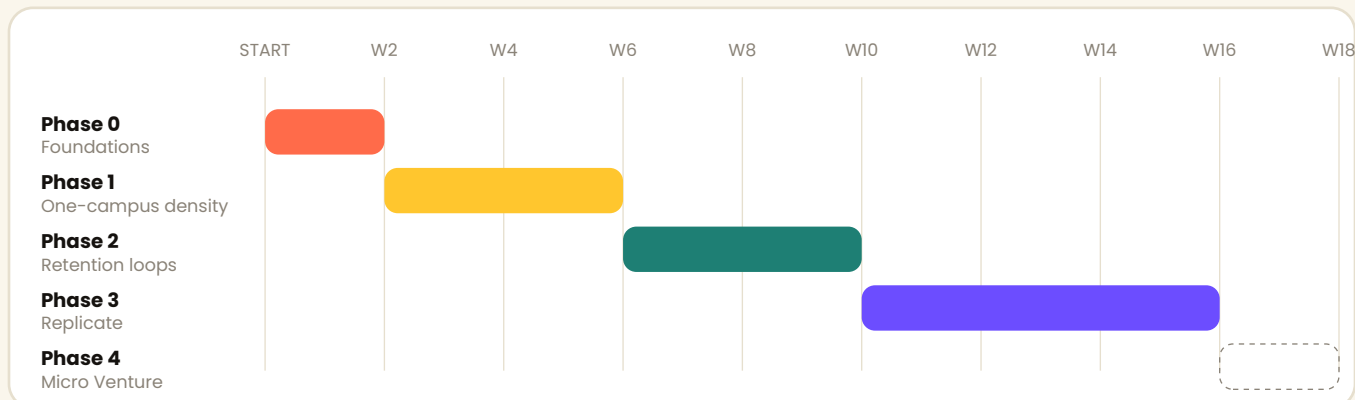
Our timing hook

Fizz rode lockdown loneliness. Find the equivalent for Mad Monkey: a recurring, urgent need for students on campus. Hackathon deadlines, fest weeks and project-team season are candidates. Test which one students feel most.

06 | ROADMAP

16 weeks to a repeatable campus playbook

One campus first. Each phase ends with a gate. If the gate fails, we fix before moving on.



PHASE 0 | WEEKS 1-2

Foundations

- Get the real numbers: users, per-college split, retention, ambassador count and activity, spend.
- Analytics dashboard live with the events on page 5.
- Waitlist and landing page up. Draft store listings.
- Decide the verification method and who owns moderation.
- Pick the beachhead campus. Home-turf candidate: VIT Chennai, because someone on the team knows the campus, which was Fizz's edge at Stanford.
- **Gate:** we can see activation, response time and retention for the current users.

PHASE 1 | WEEKS 3-6

One-campus density sprint

- 5-10 ambassadors under one launch lead, 5 club connectors (Build Spark first).
- Team seeds Sparks daily. Moderators on from day one.
- Launch event with campus unlock counter. Chai, snacks and merch as incentives.
- UGC test: 20 product-as-hero videos, then double down on whatever pops.
- **Aim:** ~10% of the target student base in two weeks, the Fizz benchmark.*
- **Gate:** most Sparks get a response within minutes, not hours.*

PHASE 2 | WEEKS 7-10

Retention loops

- Ship the shareable 'team formed' and 'Spark filled' cards.
- Email and push sequences. Feedback board live, top requests shipped.
- Find what the retained users did in their first 48 hours and push everyone toward it.
- **Gate:** D7 retention holds at or above the baseline we set in Phase 0.*

PHASE 3 | WEEKS 11-16

Replicate on campuses 2 and 3

- Turn Phase 1 into a checklist: kit, ambassador contract, moderator training, event run-sheet.
- Launch campus 2 with the checklist, campus 3 with a lighter team.
- Track cost per activated user and ambassador yield (signups per ambassador).
- **Gate:** campus 2 reaches density in about half the time campus 1 took.*

PHASE 4 | LATER

Micro Venture and Venture Club

- Merchant onboarding is a different two-sided problem. Don't start until density is proven.
- Student-referred merchants only after students actually return to the app.
- Venture Club comes in once Build Sparks are producing real teams.

Scorecard

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS US	STARTING TARGET*
Campus penetration	Share of the target base signed up and verified	~10% in 2 weeks (Fizz)
Activation	Signups who post or accept a Spark within 48 hours	Set from Phase 0 baseline
Response rate	Sparks that get a response within 15 min	Majority; recalibrate
Retention	D1, D7, D30 return	Set from Phase 0 baseline
UGC hit rate	Videos that pop vs. posted	~1 in 20 (Tolan)
Ambassador yield	Signups per active ambassador	Measure in Phase 1
Cost per activated user	Spend divided by activated users	Measure in Phase 1

*Starred targets are my starting hypotheses, not benchmarks from the research. Only the Fizz ~10% and Tolan 1-in-20 figures come from the notes. Recalibrate all of them with Mad Monkey's actual data.

What to find out and decide now

ASK LAKSHMAN

Data and context

- Current users, and the split by college.
- Ambassador count, colleges, and whether there's a WhatsApp group.
- Signups vs. users who posted or accepted a Spark. D1/D7/D30 if tracked.
- Where users came from, spend so far, what already flopped.
- Live on both stores? Analytics stack, and read access to it.
- Target users, campuses and date. Who owns growth day to day.

RESEARCH STILL TO DO

Gaps in my notes

- How many Indian colleges issue student emails.
- Cost and flow of ID-based and automated student verification.
- DPDP Act duties for under-18 users and location data.
- How Indian campus apps seeded their first campuses, with real numbers.
- Minimum users per campus for Spark response times to feel instant.

DECIDE THIS WEEK

Decisions

- Beachhead campus.
- Verification method for beta.
- Who moderates and who owns legal and safety.
- Ambassador incentive: cash, perks or both.
- Build Spark first or both Spark types from day one.

The sentence to keep in mind

Start with a group small enough to unlock network effects, and make the product the star of everything we show.